Activity 5 — The Angry Delivery Call — Logistics Hotline

Topic	5 — Customer Service Over the Phone
Mapping	LO1 · Apply telephone etiquette, paraphrasing and hold technique with an angry caller.
Format	Role Play
Duration	15 minutes
Roles	Pairs, seated back to back so there is no visual channel. A = Hotline Officer, B = Mr Faisal.

The Scenario

You work the customer hotline for a Singapore last-mile logistics firm. Mr Faisal calls at 4:15pm. His package — a replacement CPAP machine part his father needs — was due Monday. It is now Thursday. Tracking has said 'out for delivery' for three days. He has called twice before; both times he was told 'it will be delivered today'. He opens the call at volume: 'I've been lied to twice. Don't tell me it's out for delivery. Where is my package?'

What you find while he is talking: the parcel was mis-sorted to the Jurong hub on Monday, scanned back out Wednesday, and is genuinely on a van today — but the van's route ends at 9pm and he is stop 61 of 68. You can request a priority re-route (needs hub supervisor approval, ~10 minutes) or offer next-morning guaranteed delivery before 10am.

What You Will Produce

A complete recorded-style call demonstrating the six-stage phone flow with a compliant hold.

Materials: Phone flow card · Observer checklist · Timer.

Discussion Questions

1. Mr Faisal opens by shouting. What are your first words, and how long do you let him talk before you speak?
2. He says 'I've been lied to twice.' Is that true? How do you respond to it without blaming a colleague or defending the company?
3. Write the exact sentence you would use to paraphrase his issue back to him.
4. You need 10 minutes to get supervisor approval. How do you place him on hold correctly — what four things must you say?
5. You have two options (priority re-route vs guaranteed next morning). Do you choose for him or offer both? Why?

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6. Why does the CPAP detail change how you handle this call, and what would you have missed if you had interrupted him?

Step-by-Step

1. Seat the pair back to back. This is not a gimmick — removing the visual channel is the entire point of practising phone service.
2. B (Mr Faisal) reads the customer brief only. B must open at high volume and must mention the CPAP machine and his father within the first 40 seconds, unprompted.
3. A answers within three rings with the full greeting: company, own name, offer of help. A smiles before speaking — it changes the voice even though nobody can see it.
4. A does NOT speak again until B has finished venting. A may use minimal acknowledgement sounds ('mm-hm', 'I see') but no sentences and no interruptions.
5. A acknowledges the experience first, then paraphrases the whole issue back including the father and the CPAP part. A waits for B to confirm the paraphrase is right before moving on.
6. A places B on hold correctly: 'May I put you on hold for about three minutes while I get my hub supervisor to authorise a priority re-route? ... Thank you for waiting.' All four elements, in order.
7. A returns and presents BOTH options with a recommendation and a reason tied to the father's need. A lets B choose.
8. A closes with concrete next steps: what will happen, by when, who will call, and a reference number. Vague closes ('we'll look into it') fail this step.
9. A commits to ONE proactive follow-up — a call tomorrow confirming delivery, made whether or not it succeeded.
10. Observer scores: interruption count (target 0), paraphrase accuracy, all four hold elements present, and whether the close contained a time and an owner.

Debrief — What a Strong Answer Looks Like

- Let him finish. The first 30–45 seconds are venting and contain the CPAP detail — the single most important fact in the call. An officer who interrupts to defend the tracking system never learns why this parcel matters.
- 'I've been lied to twice' — do not defend and do not blame. 'You were given a delivery promise twice and it did not happen. That's on us.' Acknowledging the customer's EXPERIENCE is not admitting to a lie.
- Good paraphrase: 'So your father's CPAP part was promised Monday, you've called twice, been told it's out for delivery each time, and four days on you still have nothing.' Naming the father is what proves you listened.

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- Correct hold has four parts: ask permission, state the reason, give a realistic duration, thank them on return. Missing any one of these makes the hold feel like being dumped.
- Offer both options with a recommendation. The CPAP context makes guaranteed 10am delivery likely better than stop 61 at 9pm — but it is his father and his call. Choosing FOR the customer removes the one piece of control he still has.
- This call is a Topic 7 case in disguise: the mis-sort is the fault, but the SERVICE failure is two false promises. Note it for the feedback loop — the fix is not promising a date the system cannot see.

Check Your Work

You did not interrupt during the opening vent, your paraphrase included the father/CPAP detail, your hold had all four elements, and your close named a specific time and owner.

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